

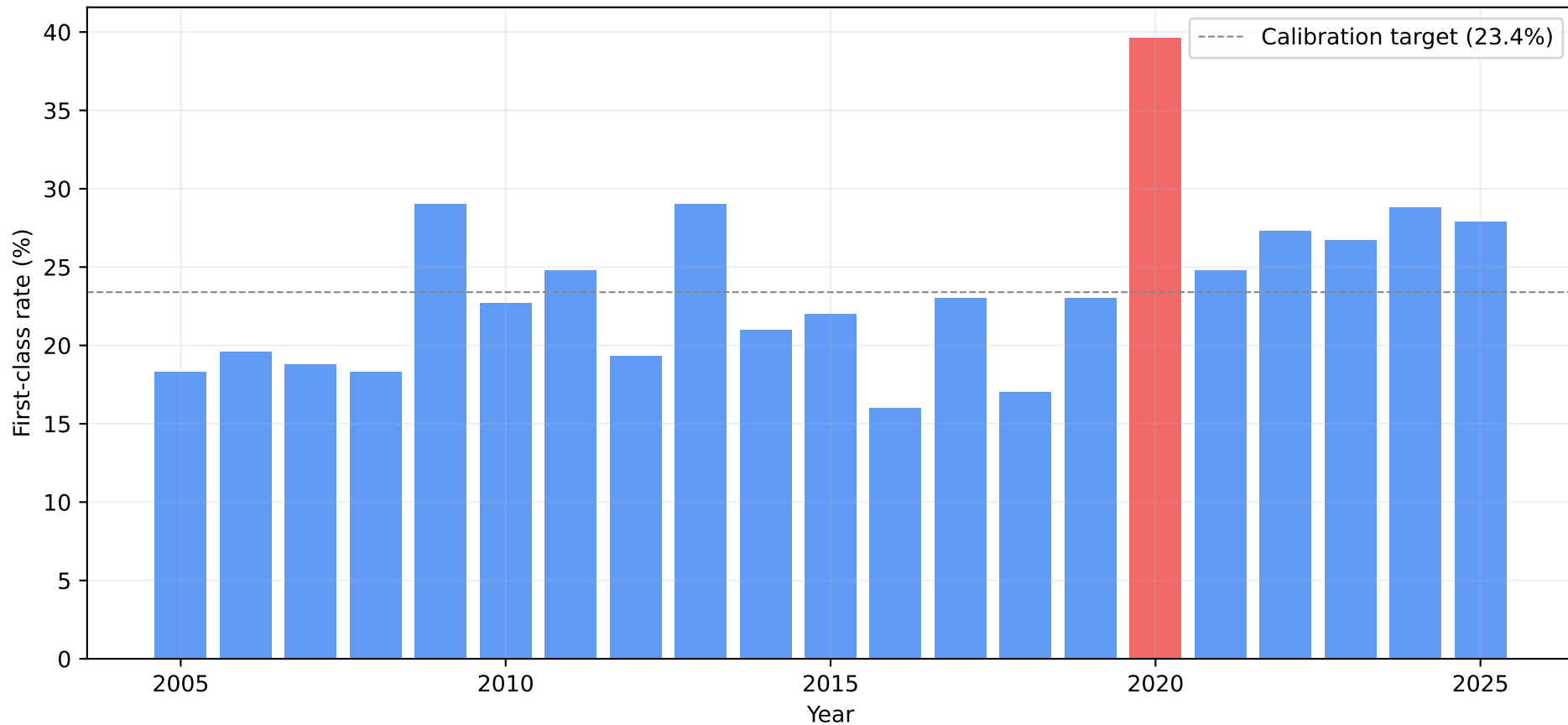
Oxford PPE Finals

Statistical Analysis of Examiners' Reports 2011–2025

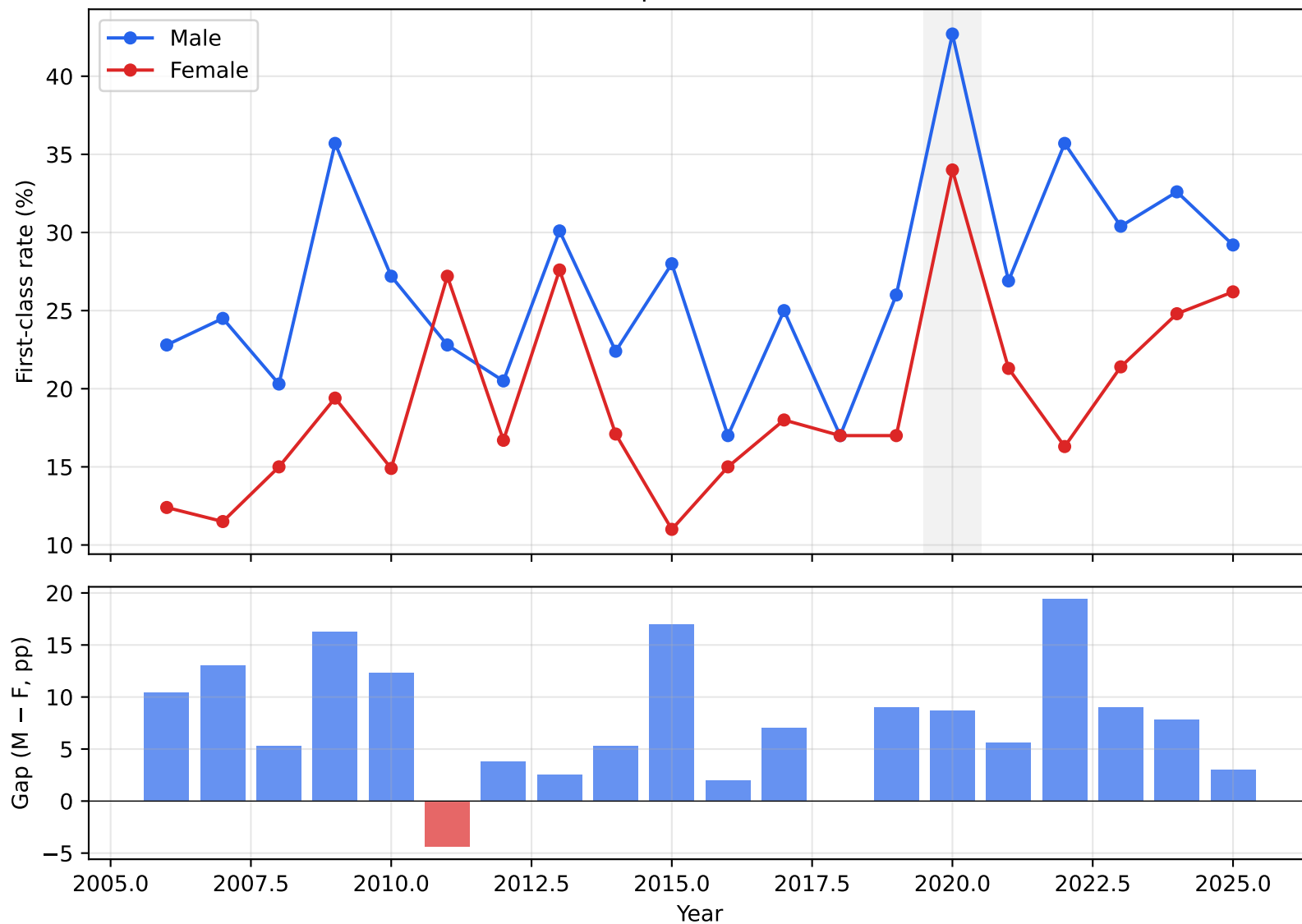
81 papers fitted · 100k Monte Carlo simulations · 15 years of data

$\sigma_{\text{ability}} = 2.74$ | Calibration target: 23.4% first rate

Overall First-Class Rate, PPE Finals (2005-2025)



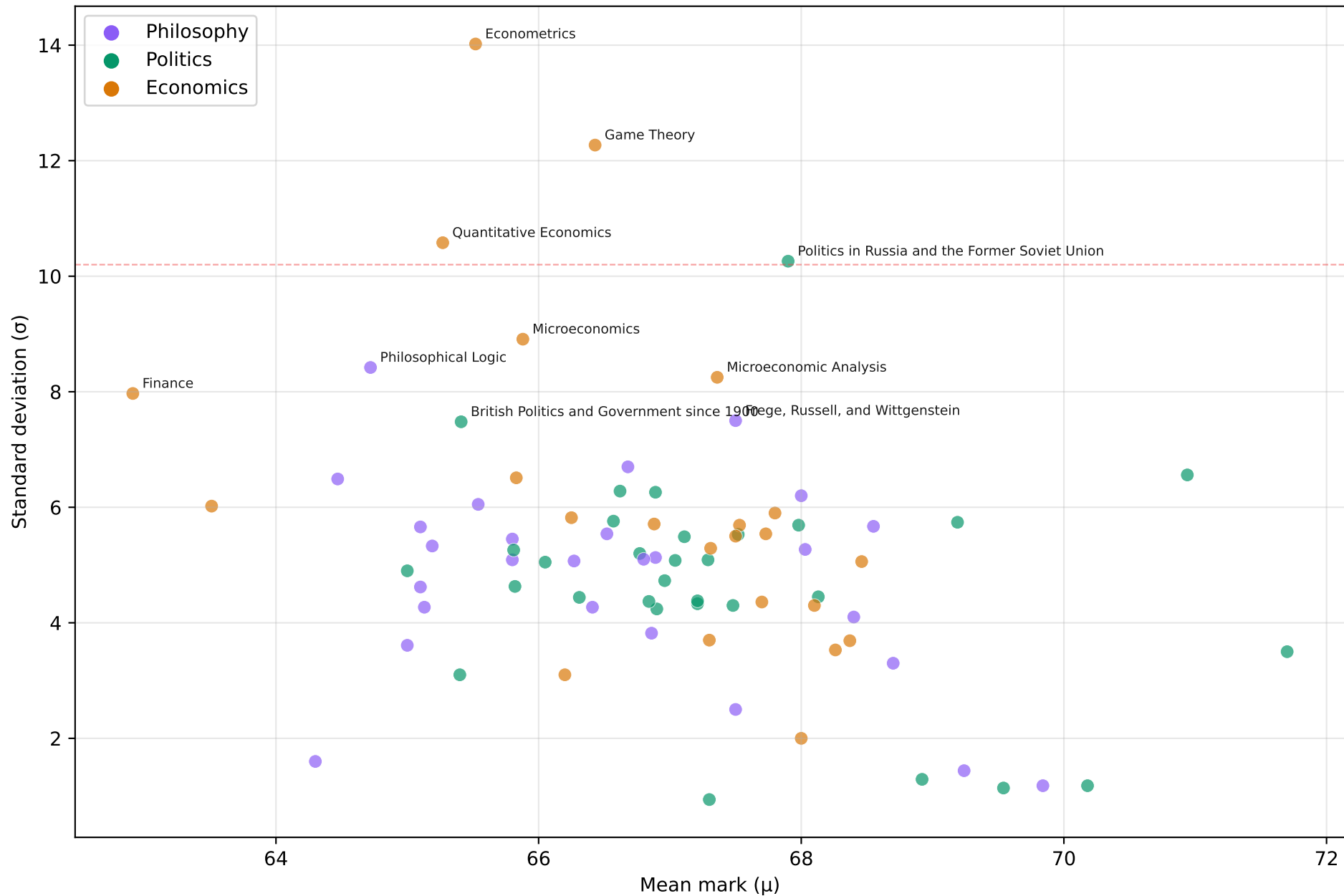
Gender Gap in First-Class Rate



Subject-Level Summary

Subject	Mean	SD	Papers	Total n	First Rate	Within Var	Between Var	Ratio
Philosophy	65.63	5.42	27	3289	21.2%	30.2	0.89	34.0
Politics	66.82	5.58	31	4060	28.5%	32.85	1.12	29.3
Economics	66.09	8.09	23	3944	30.8%	71.84	0.96	75.0

Paper Risk/Reward: Mean vs Volatility



Highest Mean (Easiest Papers)

#	Paper	Subject	μ	σ	%1st	%<50
1	Supervised Dissertation in Politics	Politics	71.7	3.5	68.6	0.0
2	Thesis in Politics	Politics	70.9	6.6	55.7	0.1
3	The Politics of the European Union	Politics	70.2	1.2	56.1	0.0
4	Special Subject in Philosophy: Feminist Theor	Philosophy	69.8	1.2	44.6	0.0
5	International Relations in the Era of Two Wor	Politics	69.5	1.1	34.3	0.0
6	Special Subject in Philosophy: Feminism and P	Philosophy	69.2	1.4	29.9	0.0
7	Politics in South Asia	Politics	69.2	5.7	44.4	0.0
8	Special Subject in Politics: Comparative Poli	Politics	68.9	1.3	20.1	0.0
9	Philosophy of Cognitive Science	Philosophy	68.7	3.3	34.7	0.0
10	The Philosophy of Wittgenstein	Philosophy	68.5	5.7	39.9	0.1
11	Behavioural and Experimental Economics	Economics	68.5	5.1	38.0	0.0
12	Philosophy of Science	Philosophy	68.4	4.1	34.8	0.0
13	Special Subject in Economics: Environmental E	Economics	68.4	3.7	32.9	0.0
14	Economics of Developing Countries	Economics	68.3	3.5	31.1	0.0
15	Marx and Marxism	Politics	68.1	4.5	33.7	0.0

Lowest Mean (Hardest Papers)

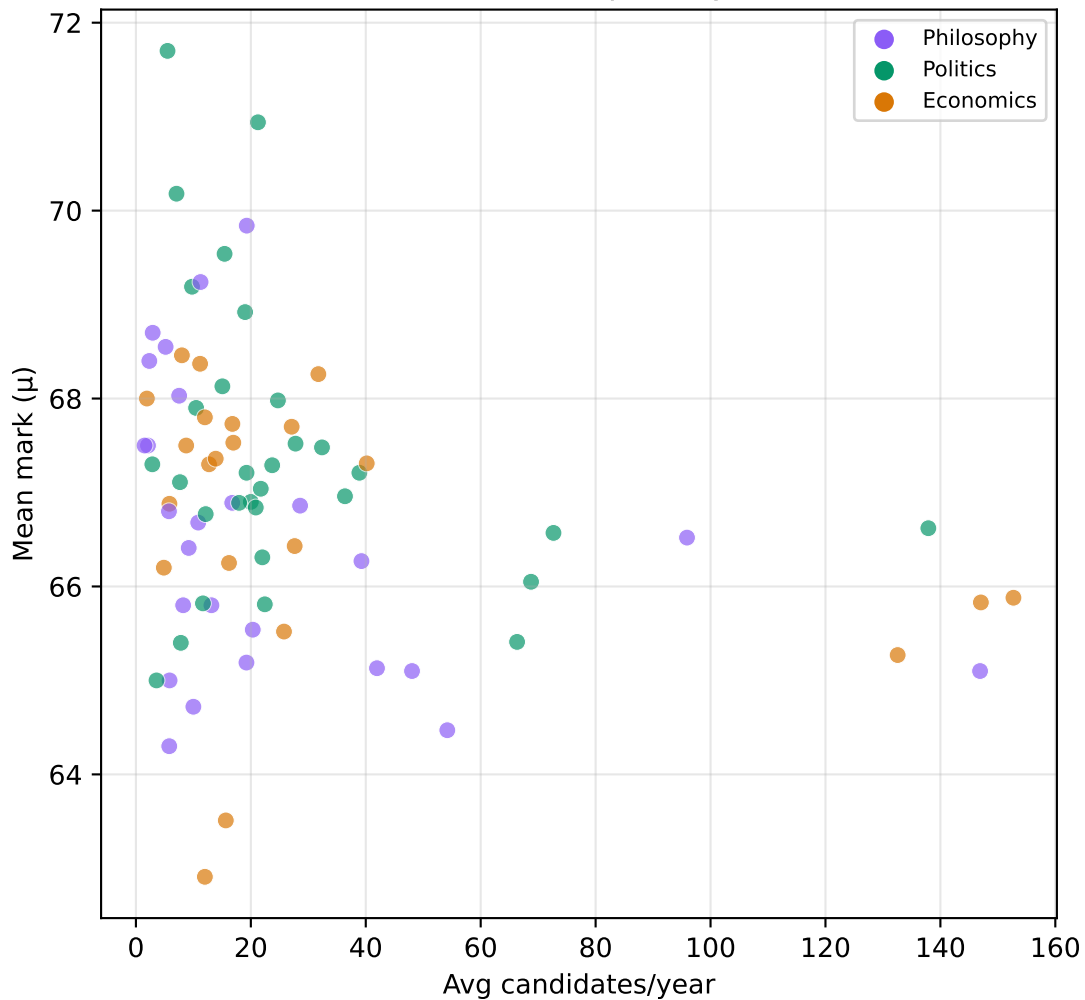
#	Paper	Subject	μ	σ	%1st	%<50
1	Finance	Economics	62.9	8.0	18.7	5.3
2	Labour Economics and Industrial Relations	Economics	63.5	6.0	14.1	1.2
3	Philosophy of Science and Social Science	Philosophy	64.3	1.6	0.0	0.0
4	Knowledge and Reality	Philosophy	64.5	6.5	19.7	1.3
5	Philosophical Logic	Philosophy	64.7	8.4	26.5	4.0
6	Quantitative Methods in Politics and Sociolog	Politics	65.0	4.9	15.4	0.1
7	The Philosophy of Kant	Philosophy	65.0	3.6	8.3	0.0
8	Ethics	Philosophy	65.1	5.7	19.3	0.4
9	Early Modern Philosophy	Philosophy	65.1	4.6	14.4	0.1
10	Plato: Republic	Philosophy	65.1	4.3	12.7	0.0
11	Aesthetics and the Philosophy of Criticism	Philosophy	65.2	5.3	18.3	0.2
12	Quantitative Economics	Economics	65.3	10.6	32.7	7.5
13	Politics in Europe	Politics	65.4	3.1	6.9	0.0
14	British Politics and Government since 1900	Politics	65.4	7.5	27.0	2.0
15	Econometrics	Economics	65.5	14.0	37.0	13.5

Highest Volatility (σ)

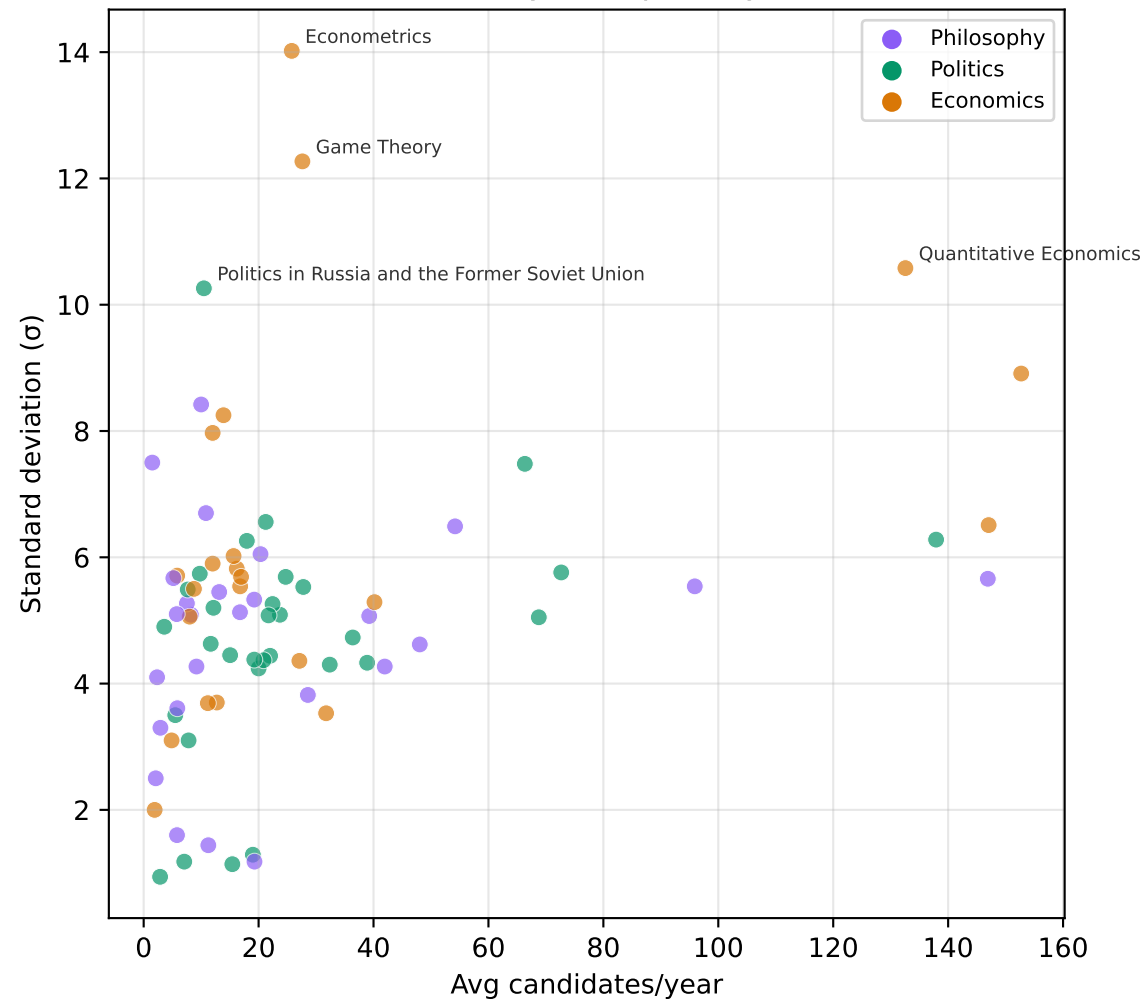
#	Paper	Subject	μ	σ	%1st	%<50
1	Econometrics	Economics	65.5	14.0	37.0	13.5
2	Game Theory	Economics	66.4	12.3	38.4	9.1
3	Quantitative Economics	Economics	65.3	10.6	32.7	7.5
4	Politics in Russia and the Former Soviet Unio	Politics	67.9	10.3	41.8	4.1
5	Microeconomics	Economics	65.9	8.9	32.2	3.7
6	Philosophical Logic	Philosophy	64.7	8.4	26.5	4.0
7	Microeconomic Analysis	Economics	67.4	8.2	37.4	1.8
8	Finance	Economics	62.9	8.0	18.7	5.3
9	Frege, Russell, and Wittgenstein	Philosophy	67.5	7.5	36.9	1.0
10	British Politics and Government since 1900	Politics	65.4	7.5	27.0	2.0
11	Philosophy of Logic and Language	Philosophy	66.7	6.7	31.0	0.6
12	Thesis in Politics	Politics	70.9	6.6	55.7	0.1
13	Macroeconomics	Economics	65.8	6.5	26.1	0.8
14	Knowledge and Reality	Philosophy	64.5	6.5	19.7	1.3
15	International Relations	Politics	66.6	6.3	29.5	0.4

Popularity vs Difficulty/Volatility ($r_{\text{mean}}=-0.28$, $p=0.013$ | $r_{\text{sigma}}=0.32$, $p=0.004$)

Mean vs Popularity



Volatility vs Popularity



Temporal Trends in Paper Mean Marks ($p < 0.10$)

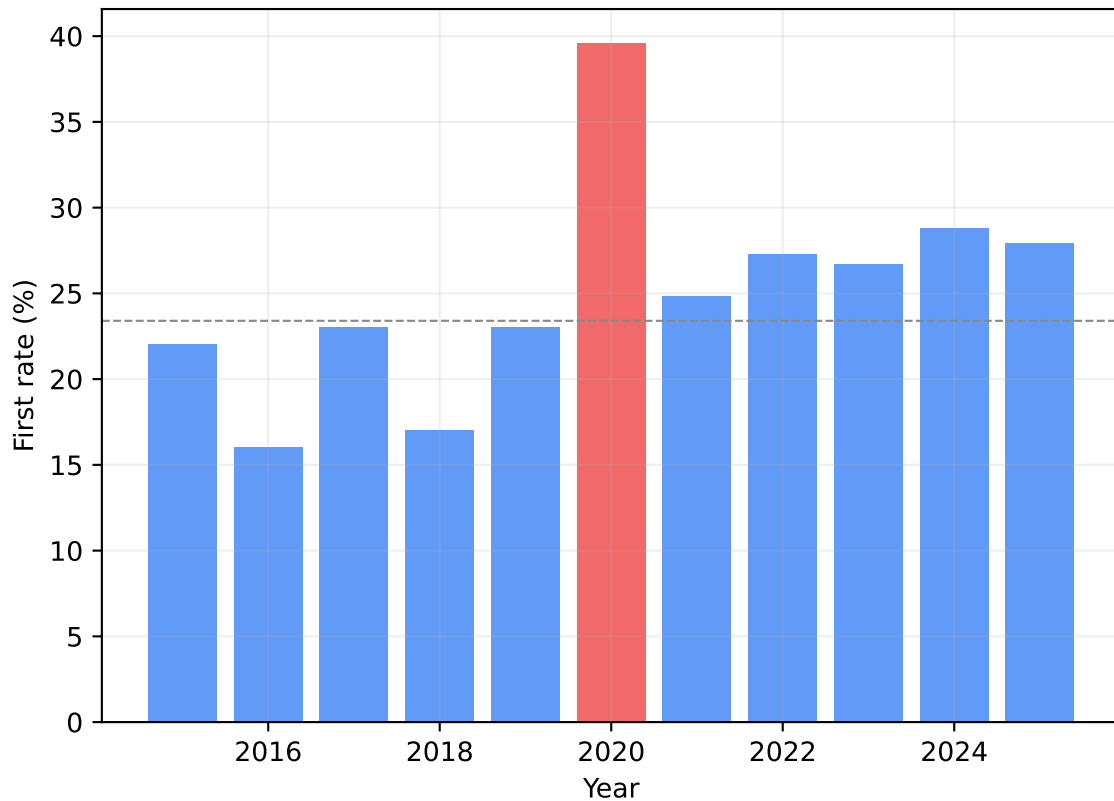
Paper	Subject	Slope	95% CI	p-value	R ²	n
Philosophical Logic	Philosophy	-1.014	[-1.518, -0.510]	0.0035	0.843	7
Microeconomic Analysis	Economics	+1.651	[+0.817, +2.485]	0.0053	0.883	6
Thesis in Politics	Politics	+0.375	[+0.072, +0.679]	0.0246	0.669	7
Game Theory	Economics	+0.419	[-0.010, +0.849]	0.0541	0.433	9
Money and Banking	Economics	-0.194	[-0.406, +0.017]	0.0664	0.403	9
Political Thought: Plato to Rousseau	Politics	+0.262	[-0.027, +0.552]	0.0671	0.521	7
Quantitative Economics	Economics	+0.412	[-0.044, +0.867]	0.0678	0.519	7
Public Economics	Economics	+0.379	[-0.051, +0.810]	0.0730	0.506	7
Politics in South Asia	Politics	+0.506	[-0.084, +1.097]	0.0785	0.493	7
Political Thought: Bentham to Weber	Politics	+0.407	[-0.075, +0.889]	0.0823	0.485	7
Politics in Russia and the Former Soviet	Politics	+0.567	[-0.139, +1.273]	0.0897	0.554	6
Special Subject in Economics: Environmen	Economics	-0.321	[-0.705, +0.063]	0.0902	0.317	10
Comparative Government	Politics	+0.114	[-0.026, +0.254]	0.0948	0.347	9
Government and Politics of the United St	Politics	+0.331	[-0.079, +0.741]	0.0976	0.343	9

Marginal Paper Value: Effect of 8th Paper on P(1st)
Baseline = 23.2% with Comparative Government

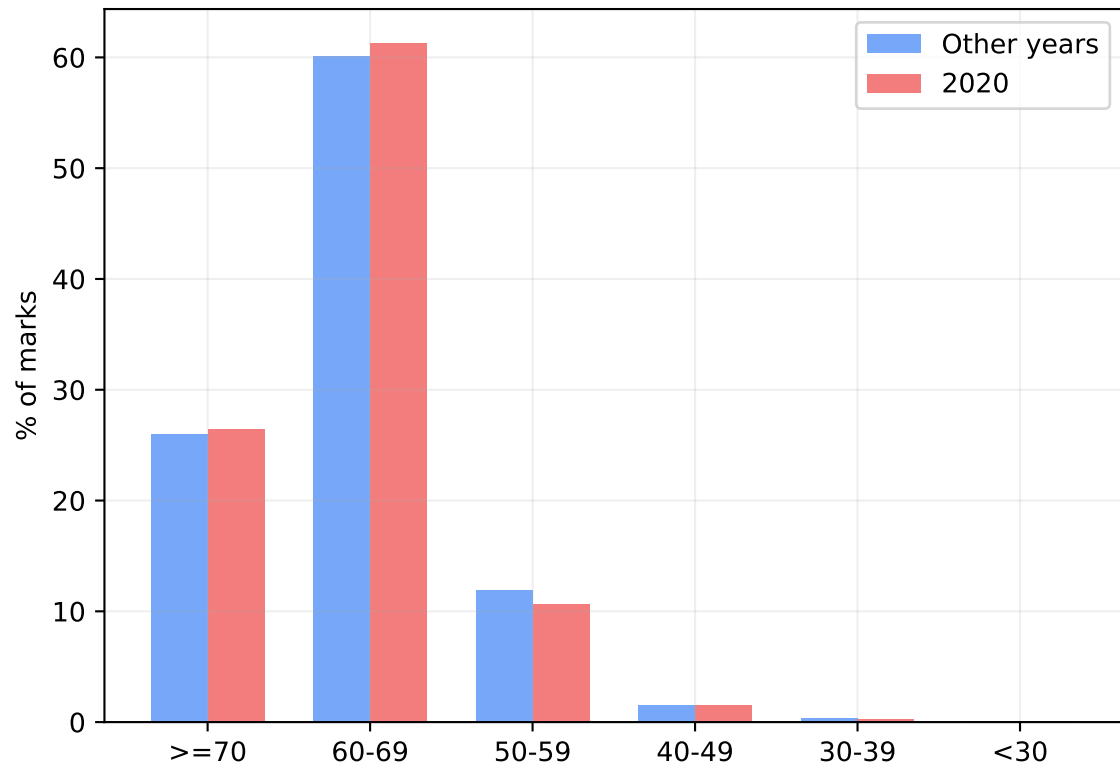
Paper	Subject	μ	σ	P(1st)	$\Delta P(1st)$
Supervised Dissertation in Politics	Politics	71.7	3.5	28.6%	+5.4%
Thesis in Politics	Politics	70.9	6.6	28.0%	+4.8%
The Politics of the European Union	Politics	70.2	1.2	26.9%	+3.6%
Special Subject in Philosophy: Feminist	Philosophy	69.8	1.2	26.4%	+3.2%
International Relations in the Era of Tw	Politics	69.5	1.1	26.1%	+2.8%
Politics in South Asia	Politics	69.2	5.7	26.0%	+2.8%
Special Subject in Philosophy: Feminism	Philosophy	69.2	1.4	25.7%	+2.5%
Special Subject in Politics: Comparative	Politics	68.9	1.3	25.4%	+2.1%
The Philosophy of Wittgenstein	Philosophy	68.5	5.7	25.3%	+2.1%
Politics in Russia and the Former Soviet	Politics	67.9	10.3	25.2%	+2.0%
...					
The Philosophy of Kant	Philosophy	65.0	3.6	21.3%	-1.9%
Knowledge and Reality	Philosophy	64.5	6.5	21.2%	-2.0%
Philosophy of Science and Social Science	Philosophy	64.3	1.6	20.6%	-2.6%
Labour Economics and Industrial Relation	Economics	63.5	6.0	20.2%	-3.0%
Finance	Economics	62.9	8.0	19.9%	-3.3%

COVID 2020: First Rate Doubled Despite Identical Paper-Level Marks

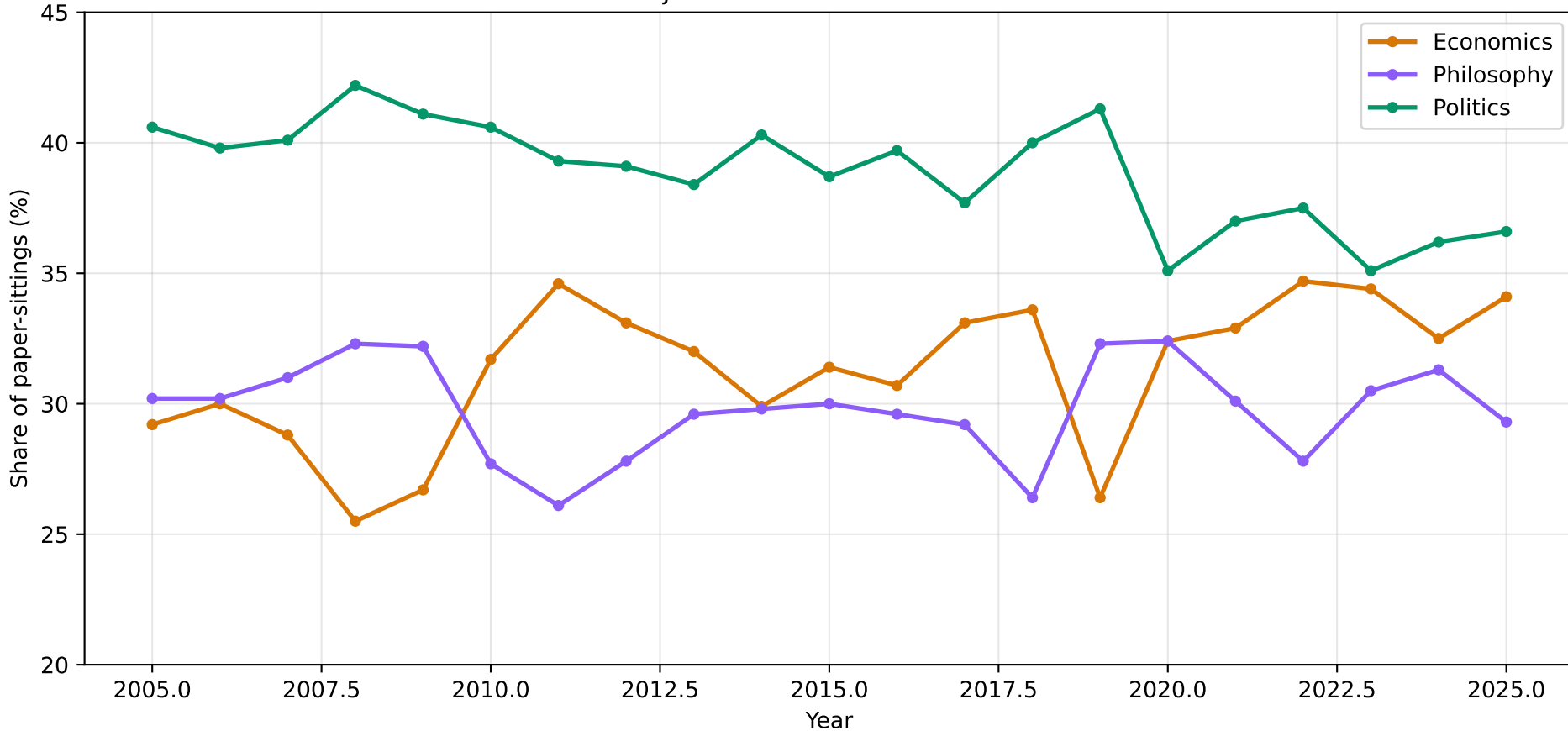
First-Class Rate (2020 in red)



Band Distribution: 2020 vs Other Years

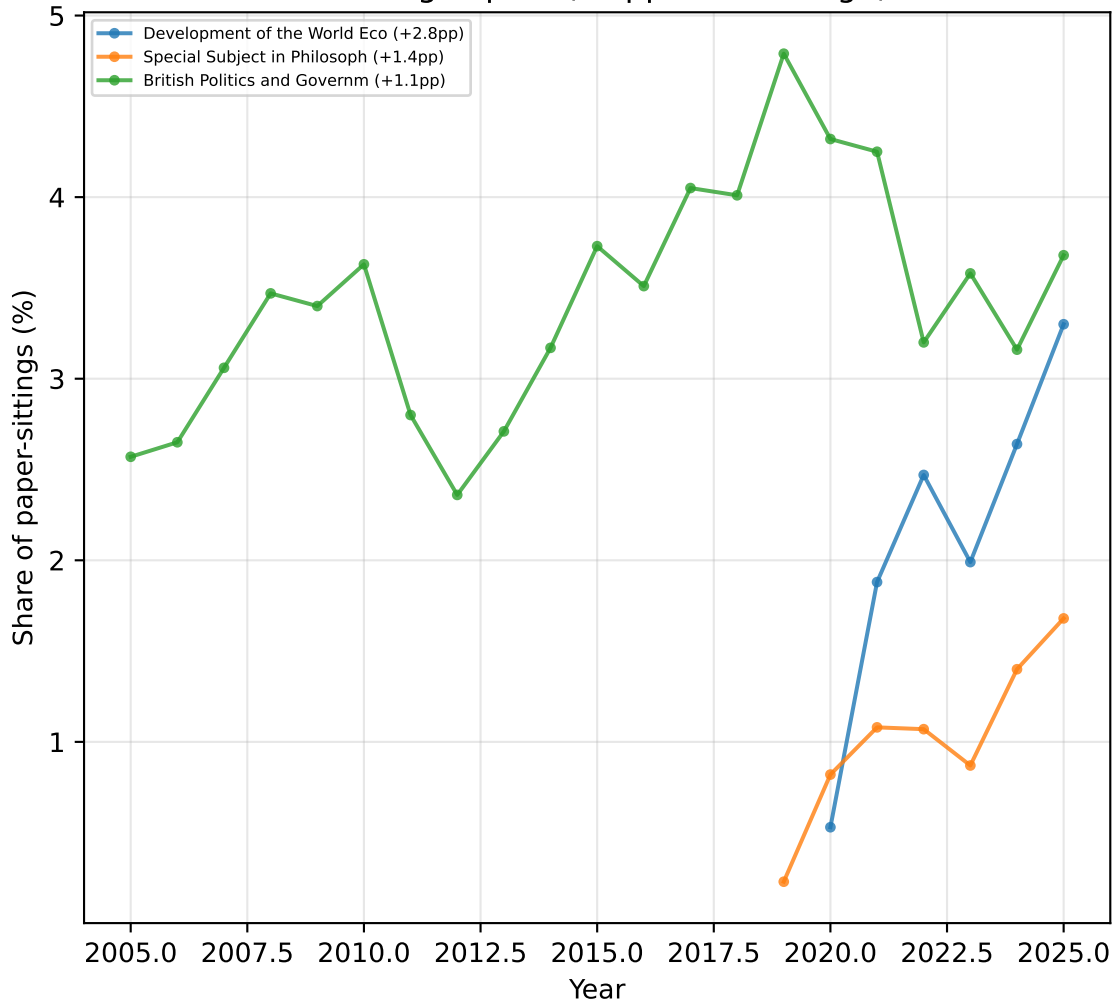


Subject Market Share Over Time

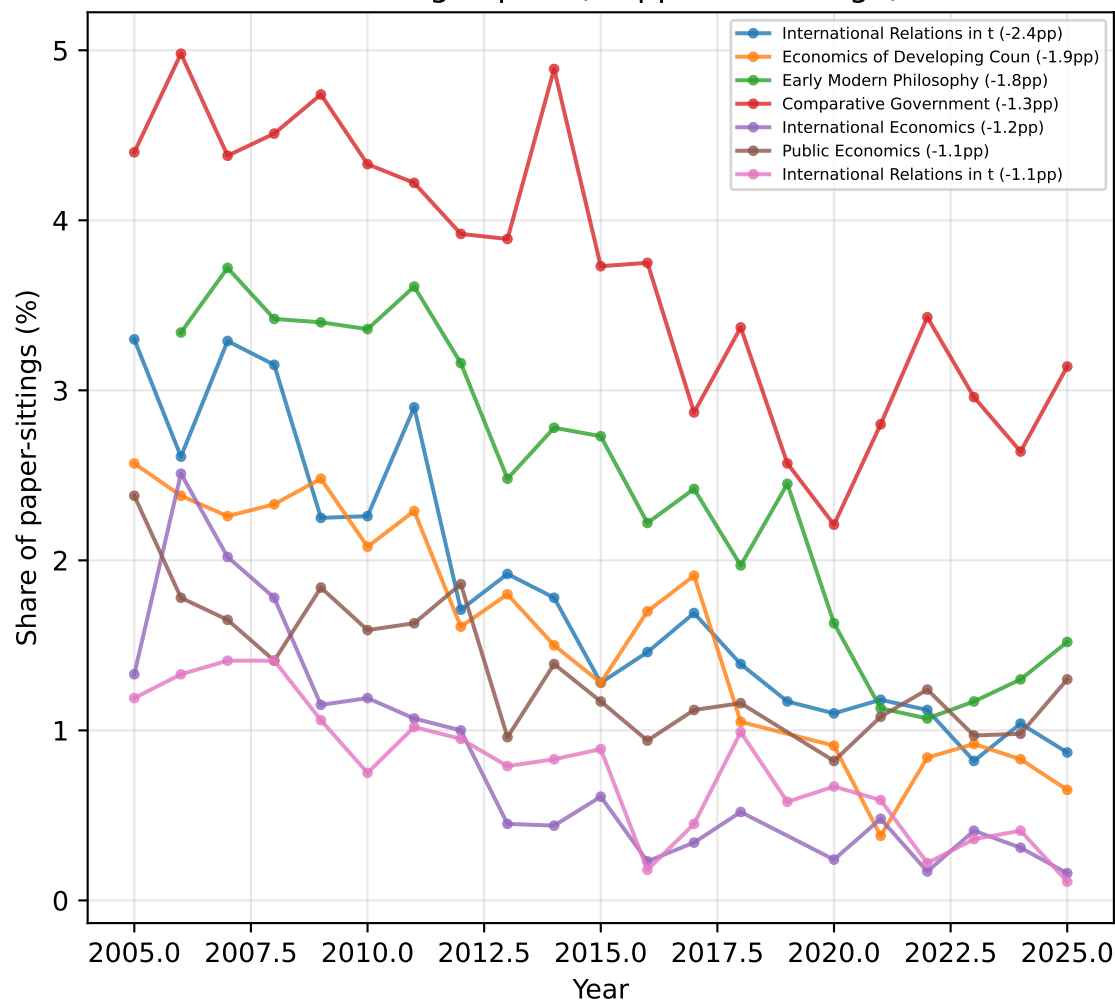


Paper Popularity Trends (share of all paper-sittings, significant trends with >1pp change)

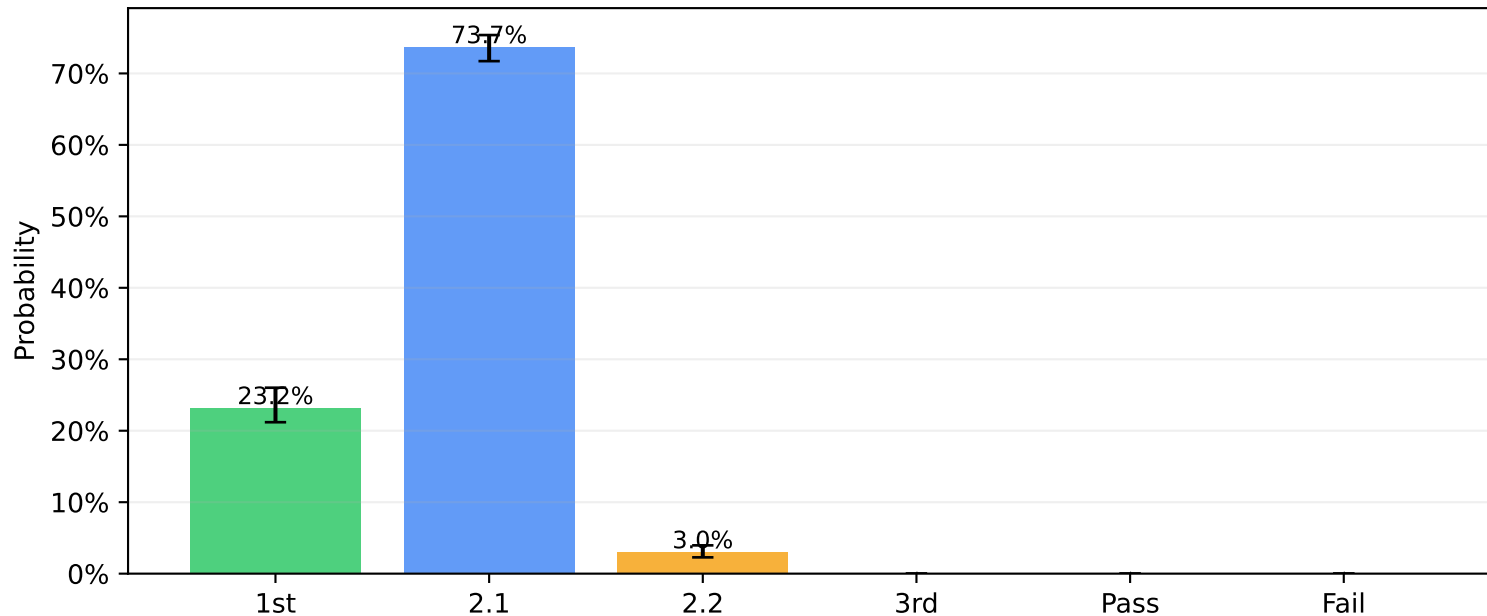
Growing Papers (>1pp total change)



Declining Papers (>1pp total change)



Classification Probabilities for a Typical Student
(8 most popular papers: Microeconomics, Macroeconomics, Ethics + 5 more)
Error bars = 95% bootstrap CI from resampling year-level data



Kingmaker Papers ($\sigma \geq 2 \times \text{median } \sigma = 10.2$; median $\sigma = 5.1$)

#	Paper	Subject	μ	σ	Total n
1	Econometrics	Economics	65.5	14.0	170
2	Game Theory	Economics	66.4	12.3	157
3	Quantitative Economics	Economics	65.3	10.6	644
4	Politics in Russia and the Former Soviet Unio	Politics	67.9	10.3	45

Methodology Notes

Distribution fitting

Truncated normal (support [0,100]) fitted via MLE on pooled band counts.

6 bins: ≥ 70 , 60–69, 50–59, 40–49, 30–39, < 30 .

81 papers fitted (65 band MLE, 16 moment estimates). 2020 excluded.

Goodness of fit: chi-squared test (bins merged where expected < 5).

Classification rules

1st: $\text{avg} \geq 68.5$, ≥ 2 marks of 70+, no mark < 50 .

2.1: $\text{avg} \geq 59.0$, ≥ 3 marks of 60+.

2.2: $\text{avg} \geq 49.0$, ≥ 3 marks of 50+.

3rd: $\text{avg} \geq 40.0$, ≥ 3 marks of 40+.

Monte Carlo simulation

$\text{mark}_i = \mu_i + \theta + \varepsilon_i$, $\theta \sim N(0, \sigma^2_{\text{ability}})$, $\varepsilon_i \sim N(0, \sigma^2_{\text{paper}} - \sigma^2_{\text{ability}})$.

$\sigma_{\text{ability}} = 2.74$, calibrated to 23.4% first-class rate.

100,000 simulations per paper combination.

Temporal trends

OLS regression of mean mark on year, excluding 2020.

95% CI: $\text{slope} \pm t_{\{n-2, 0.025\}} \times \text{stderr}$.

Key limitations

- Truncated normal may poorly fit papers with ceiling effects or bimodality.
- Single-factor ability model; same-subject papers may be more correlated.
- Selection effects: observed distributions reflect who chose the paper.
- Temporal pooling: distributions are averages across years, not year-specific.